Opening More Forest Land May Not Fix Loggers' Biggest Problems

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President Trump is widely expected to soon open about 44 million acres of the country's last **pristine** national forests, a move he says will bring **timber** jobs back to struggling small towns and help prevent wildfires in overgrown land. Last year he signed executive actions to boost **timber** sales and reverse the 25-year-old Roadless Rule, which has blocked most new logging on undeveloped national forest land since 2001. The formal repeal is expected early next year. But people who make a living in the forests say the problems are much bigger than access to more trees. Sean Smith, chief executive of Starfire Lumber in Cottage Grove, Oregon, says pressing challenges start with the record-high price of **diesel** fuel, and **inflation** pushing up steel, sawblades, ball bearings and many other parts. Smith supports the reversal, saying it could eventually give mills a more reliable local supply, and that much of the nearby Willamette National Forest is dangerously overgrown, making it more prone to **catastrophic** wildfires. But the Forest Service has struggled to get such projects going even on forests that already have roads, facing lawsuits, red tape and too few workers. Second-generation logger Jeff Brink says few people want to wake at 2 a.m. and drive a log truck for about the same pay as working at McDonald's. **Timber** sales on federal land have dropped by close to 90 percent since the 1990s, the report says, because of tighter environmental laws and cheaper Canadian lumber imports, and about 400 mills across the Northwest have closed since then, costing about 35,000 jobs. Experts project that overturning the Roadless Rule could raise federal **timber** sales by only five to ten percent. Environmental groups plan to sue, and retired firefighter Timothy Ingalsbee argues that more roads could bring more human-caused wildfires.

Word Treasure

pristine -- In its natural state, not changed or damaged by people.
timber -- Wood from trees that is used for building or making things.
catastrophic -- Causing very great damage or harm.
inflation -- A general rise in prices over time.
diesel -- A kind of fuel used by many trucks and machines.

Background you need

National forests are large areas of public forest land, and timber is wood cut from trees for building and other uses.

A rule can block most new roads and logging on undeveloped forest land, even when some people want more timber work there.

Loggers, truck drivers, and mills turn trees into wood products, and their work depends on fuel, parts, workers, and buyers as well as on trees.

Overgrown forest land can hold a lot of dry plants and small trees, which can make wildfires harder to control once they start.

Break it down

LEAD: Opening more forest land may not fix loggers' biggest problems, even though it is widely expected soon.

KEY EVENT: President Trump is widely expected to open about 44 million acres of the country's last pristine national forests.

+- WHO: President Trump, Sean Smith of Starfire Lumber, logger Jeff Brink, and retired firefighter Timothy Ingalsbee.

+- WHY IT IS PROPOSED: Trump says it will bring timber jobs back to struggling small towns and help prevent wildfires in overgrown land.

+- THE COUNTERPOINT: People who work in the forests say fuel prices, parts costs, workers, lawsuits, and red tape matter more than access to trees.

EVIDENCE: Timber sales on federal land have dropped by close to 90 percent since the 1990s, and about 400 mills across the Northwest have closed since then, costing about 35,000 jobs.

OPEN QUESTION: Will the formal repeal happen early next year, and will it raise timber sales by more than the projected five to ten percent?

Why it matters

Decisions about forests affect jobs in small towns, the price and supply of wood, and the risk of wildfires, so opening land alone may not settle the argument.

Test what you remember

1. **About how many acres of national forest is President Trump widely expected to soon open?**
   - (A) About 90 acres
   - (B) About 400 acres
   - (C) About 35,000 acres
   - (D) About 44 million acres
2. **Since when has the Roadless Rule blocked most new logging on undeveloped national forest land?**
   - (A) Since 2001
   - (B) Since the 1990s
   - (C) Since early next year
   - (D) Since last year
3. **According to Sean Smith, what starts the pressing challenges for people working in the forests?**
   - (A) A ban on sawblades
   - (B) A shortage of trees
   - (C) Too many log trucks
   - (D) The record-high price of diesel fuel
4. **According to the report, why have timber sales on federal land dropped by close to 90 percent since the 1990s?**
   - (A) More national forests opening
   - (B) Too many new mills opening
   - (C) Falling diesel prices
   - (D) Tighter environmental laws and cheaper Canadian lumber imports
5. **By how much do experts project that overturning the Roadless Rule could raise federal timber sales?**
   - (A) Close to 90 percent
   - (B) Only five to ten percent
   - (C) By 35,000 jobs
   - (D) About 44 percent
6. **What does retired firefighter Timothy Ingalsbee argue about more roads?**
   - (A) They would lower diesel prices
   - (B) They would close 400 mills
   - (C) They would stop all wildfires
   - (D) They could bring more human-caused wildfires

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. President Trump: He says opening the forests will bring timber jobs back to struggling small towns and help prevent wildfires in overgrown land.

2. Sean Smith: He supports the reversal, saying it could eventually give mills a more reliable local supply, but says diesel and parts costs are pressing challenges.

3. Environmental groups: They plan to sue over the move.

4. Timothy Ingalsbee: He argues that more roads could bring more human-caused wildfires.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):